



HIL-W breaks that continuity. There are no carryover storylines to keep the casual hockey fan invested. The core of the Warriors, for instance, turned out in the green of the Ranchi Royals this year. While playing on home turf helped attendance, such churn ultimately becomes a roadblock for the league's long-term growth.

Broadcasting plans were in place, but player-centric storytelling was conspicuously absent. Several international stars from the previous season, including Yibbi Jansen, Charlotte Englebert, and Freeke Moes, were nowhere to be seen.

Indian men's hockey, over time, has produced personalities who double up as symbols of the sport itself. The women's team, though competitive, currently lacks that shorthand: a single name that instantly anchors the team in the

public imagination. Navneet Kaur's longevity, Udita Duhan's defensive authority, and Lalremsiami's presence on the wing offer obvious entry points for sustained projection.

Despite the league allowing up to nine Indian players to start in the playing XI, only one Belgian coach was willing to depart from convention, leaving the likes of Lola Riera, Juana Castellaro, Cristina Cosentino, and Priscila Jardel on the bench during a match against the Shrachi Bengal Tigers. Sofie Gierts, heading the eventual champion SG Pipers, explained the thinking: "Look, we are in India, and it's called the Hockey India League for a reason. We want Indian players to shine, and we want them to live their dreams. It's our responsibility to put them in front. The Indian players are amazing."

Then there were the recurring

Final triumph: Deadlocked after a fierce 1-1 contest in regulation time, SG Pipers held its nerve in the shootout, edging Shrachi Bengal Tigers 3-2 to claim the Women's Hero Hockey India League 2025-26 crown.

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issues. The league's social media strategy, meant to drive emotional investment, was underwhelming. There were no meet-and-greet opportunities at popular hubs such as Nucleus Mall or the Mall of Ranchi near the venue, no contests to win signed merchandise, and no paid hospitality offering.

At times, the women's league felt like an afterthought. From the official communications partner having no on-ground presence, to a team relying on a local photographer to distribute fan jerseys to random